CASE STUDY

CYBERBULLYING

Cyberbullying is a form of online harassment where individuals are targeted through digital platforms such as social media, messaging apps, or gaming communities. A well-known real-world example is the case of Megan Meier, a teenager from Dardenne Prairie, whose tragic experience highlighted the serious consequences of online abuse.

In a typical cyberbullying scenario, the process begins when a person creates a fake profile or uses their real account to contact the victim. Initially, they may build trust through friendly conversations. Gradually, the tone shifts to manipulation, insults, or threats. The bully may then spread rumors, share private messages publicly, or encourage others to join in, amplifying the harm. This step-by-step escalation often traps the victim in a cycle of fear and humiliation.

Cyberbullying commonly targets teenagers, college students, and individuals who appear vulnerable, such as those new to a social group or lacking strong support systems. Victims may also be chosen based on appearance, opinions, or personal differences.

The consequences can be severe. Victims often experience anxiety, depression, low self-esteem, and social withdrawal. Academic performance may decline, and in extreme cases, cyberbullying can lead to self-harm or suicidal thoughts. The case of Megan Meier, for instance, led to increased awareness and stricter discussions around online safety laws.

This case study emphasizes the importance of responsible digital behavior and the need to report and prevent cyberbullying.